

THE INDIE PUBLISHER'S HANDBOOK · 2026 EDITION

Publish Your First Paid Mobile App

From idea to the App Store, Google Play, and Samsung Galaxy Store - registration, review rules, subscriptions, and a realistic 60-day plan. No code experience required.

\$124

to join all 3 stores

~60 days

idea to launch

3

worksheets included

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This handbook exists because the hard part of shipping an app in 2026 is not the code - AI agents and cross-platform templates handle most of that. The hard part is the process: three different store registrations, review rules that reject half of first submissions, and a Google Play testing requirement almost nobody warns you about. Every step here is sequenced so nothing blocks you later.

The barrier has never been lower

Publishing an app used to mean months of native development in two languages. Today one codebase ships to iPhone, Android, and the web, AI coding agents scaffold working apps from a plain-English description, and payment infrastructure comes pre-built. The store fees are the cheapest part: **\$124 covers all three stores** - \$99/year for Apple, \$25 once for Google, and Samsung is free.

What still filters out most people is everything around the code. Store registrations with identity checks that take days. Review guidelines that reject apps for a broken support link. A closed-testing rule on Google Play that adds two weeks to every first-timer's schedule. None of it is hard once you can see it coming - and after this handbook, you can.

The three-sentence business case

A niche app with a \$4.99/month subscription needs just 170 subscribers to clear \$10K/year. Niche beats general: small audiences are cheaper to reach, convert better, and rank easier in store search. Your unfair advantage is a niche you already understand professionally - build for the audience you already serve.

Design a small app well

- **One problem, one audience.** Pick something you can explain in a sentence and build a first version of in two weeks. If the pitch needs a paragraph, the app is too big.
- **Sketch the daily loop first.** Identify the three screens a user touches every day and design only those. Settings, onboarding, edge cases - all of it waits until the loop works.
- **Design the store listing on day one.** Icon, five screenshots, a one-line pitch. Store browsers judge these before they ever open your app. Worksheet C gives you the template.
- **Make the paywall a design decision.** Decide where free ends before you build: three uses, one project, or seven days. Retro-fitting a paywall into a fully-free app annoys users and reviewers alike.
- **Build with an AI stack.** Tools like Replit's agent with the official Expo + RevenueCat template generate a cross-platform app with the paywall pre-wired. You describe, it scaffolds, you refine. Alternatives: Cursor + Expo, FlutterFlow, or classic Xcode/Android Studio if you prefer code-first.

Rule of thumb: if version 1 takes more than two weeks of evenings, cut features until it doesn't. Nobody has ever regretted launching too small; every abandoned app died too big.

Join all three stores on day one

Identity verification takes days and runs in parallel with your build - start it before you write code.

Store	Cost	What to know
Apple App Store	\$99 / year	Enroll at developer.apple.com with an Apple ID (two-factor on). Individual enrollment is fine - no company paperwork. Review takes 24-48h per submission.
Google Play	\$25 once	Sign up at play.google.com/console with government-ID verification. Cheapest ticket, but see the testing rule below before planning your launch date.
Samsung Galaxy Store	Free	Register at seller.samsungapps.com , then request Commercial Seller status (name must exactly match your government ID). Accepts the same Android build you make for Google Play - with far less competition.

The rule that catches first-timers: a personal Google Play account created after Nov 13, 2023 cannot publish publicly until it passes a closed test with **12 testers opted in continuously for 14 days**. Plan those two weeks into your schedule and start recruiting testers the day you start building (Worksheet B has the scripts). Samsung has no such rule - a useful first store while the Google clock runs. Organization accounts with a D-U-N-S number are exempt.

Wire up payments once, sell everywhere

Apple and Google each have their own billing system, receipts, and edge cases. A subscription-management layer like RevenueCat abstracts both behind one SDK - free until your app earns \$2.5K/month, which is exactly the phase where you shouldn't be writing billing code.

- **Step 1 - One project, both stores.** Create a free RevenueCat account and attach your App Store and Play Store app records to a single project.
- **Step 2 - Mirror your products.** Create the products in App Store Connect and Play Console (e.g. monthly_pro at \$4.99, annual_pro at \$39.99), mirror them in RevenueCat, and group them into one entitlement your app checks.
- **Step 3 - Use a templated paywall.** Ship a proven layout instead of designing from scratch. During development everything runs in test mode - real billing switches on only when the store listing goes live.

Pricing that works for first apps

Anchor annual at roughly 7x monthly (\$4.99 / \$39.99) so the yearly plan reads as the obvious deal. Start slightly higher than feels comfortable - lowering a price later delights users; raising one annoys them. Add a 3-7 day free trial once reviews are positive, not before.

A realistic 60-day schedule

Week	Milestone
1	Lock the idea. Register Apple, Google, and Samsung accounts - verification runs while you build. Start posting your build in public.
2-3	Build the MVP from a template. Draft the icon and screenshots alongside the code, not after it.
4	Integrate the paywall, test sandbox purchases, put a beta build in friends' hands (TestFlight on iOS).
5-6	Google Play closed test running (12 testers x 14 days). Iterate on their feedback while the clock runs.
7	Submit to App Store review and Samsung Seller Portal. Fix rejections fast - broken links, missing demo accounts, and vague descriptions are the usual culprits.
8	Public release everywhere. Announce to the audience you built along the way - they are your first reviews and first customers.

The launch is a beginning, not an event

- **Build in public from week one.** Daily progress posts on Threads or X build the audience that becomes your 12 beta testers, your first reviews, and your first customers. The marketing is free, but it must start before launch.
- **Stack revenue streams.** Pair the app with digital products - templates, checklists, guides on Gumroad - so your audience has something to buy at every price point.
- **Time launches for upside.** Annual hackathons (RevenueCat's Shipaton is the biggest) award cash prizes just for shipping during their window - free money if your timeline lines up.
- **Iterate on reviews.** Your first 100 users will tell you exactly what the next version is. Ship updates monthly; both stores reward active apps with better ranking.

Tick every box before you submit

Accounts & legal

- ☐ Apple Developer Program active (\$99/yr) - two-factor enabled
- ☐ Google Play Console verified (\$25) - ID check passed
- ☐ Samsung Seller Portal - Commercial Seller status approved
- ☐ Privacy policy URL live (required by all three stores)
- ☐ Support email / page live and monitored

Product

- ☐ Core daily loop works offline / on poor network
- ☐ Paywall tested in sandbox: purchase, restore, cancel
- ☐ No placeholder text, dead buttons, or broken links anywhere
- ☐ Demo account created for reviewers (note it in review notes)
- ☐ Crash-free session rate above 99% in your beta

Listing

- ☐ App icon final at all required sizes
- ☐ 5 screenshots per platform - first one carries the pitch
- ☐ Title + subtitle include your main search keyword
- ☐ Description first line sells the outcome, not the features
- ☐ Age rating questionnaire completed honestly
- ☐ Privacy 'nutrition label' filled (Apple) / Data safety form (Google)

Distribution

- ☐ 12 Google Play testers recruited and opted in (14-day clock started)
- ☐ TestFlight beta shipped to at least 5 people
- ☐ Launch announcement drafted for your social audience

Fill your Google Play closed test in 48 hours

You need 12 people opted in continuously for 14 days. Recruit 16-18 so dropouts don't reset your clock. Three scripts, escalating from warm to cold:

Script 1 - Direct message to friends & family

Hey! I built a mobile app and Google requires 12 beta testers for 2 weeks before I can launch. All you do is install it from a link and open it now and then. Can I count you in? Takes 1 minute to set up - I'll send the link.

Script 2 - Social post (Threads / X / LinkedIn)

I need 12 beta testers for my new app [ONE-LINE PITCH]. Google Play requires a 14-day closed test before launch. Early access + your name in the credits + you shape v1. Reply with a wave emoji and I'll DM you the link. First 15 people are in.

Script 3 - Communities (Reddit, Discord, forums)

[Beta] Looking for Android testers for [APP NAME] - [ONE-LINE PITCH]. It's free for testers, feedback genuinely shapes the roadmap, and I'll share launch numbers back with this community. Comment or DM for the opt-in link. (Mods: happy to remove if not allowed.)

Keep testers opted in: the 14 days must be continuous. Message the group on day 3, 7, and 11 with a changelog ('fixed the crash you found') - engaged testers don't uninstall, and their feedback doubles as your first reviews.

Fill in the blanks, paste into the consoles

Field	Formula + your answer
App name 30 chars	[Brand] - [main keyword]
Subtitle / short desc. 30-80 chars	[Outcome] for [audience]
First description line	The one sentence a skimmer reads: outcome, not features.
Screenshot 1	Your pitch as a headline over the best screen. If they only see one image, this is it.
Screenshots 2-5	One benefit each, in the order of your daily loop.
Keywords Apple: 100 chars	Niche terms beat big ones: 'freelancer tax tracker' ranks; 'finance' never will.
Review notes	Demo login + one paragraph explaining what the app does. Reviewers reject what they can't understand in 60 seconds.

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